

concern, said it is “aware of the incident and are in the process of taking appropriate action with the concerned authority.”

Following the money

A separate admin panel shed light on the financial infrastructure underpinning these platforms, showing a web of bank accounts used to collect deposits, many of them registered under small business entities. Several of these accounts bore the hallmarks of money mule networks.

“Money mules are basically people whose bank accounts have been used to transfer fraudulent money. It has an entire syndicate to itself. There are multiple Telegram channels and Facebook groups where even today, if you want, you can drop a text saying you want to rent your bank account. All you need to do is give your bank details and your online transaction password. Post that, whenever there is any fraudulent transaction, all of that money will get routed through these money mules.

So, once you have rented your bank account, you will get a certain commission for every such transaction. The remaining amount will get transferred to other bank accounts and at the end of the day that will get converted into electronic currency. That’s when it goes out of jurisdiction,” Sourajeet elaborates.

Influence for hire

Sign-ups on these betting platforms are largely driven by tippers rather than traditional marketing campaigns. Posing as insiders with privileged knowledge of the game, these influencers cultivate audiences on Telegram, Instagram and YouTube Shorts before funnelling their followers into these networks. Their earnings are typically linked to the number of users they bring on board.

There has also been a significant uptick in the use of AI-generated deepfakes (**right**) to create tipper credibility. Sourajeet says: “They pull up these videos from different

podcasts, advertisements and so on. And then by using simple AI voice cloners or video editors, they make these celebrities endorse these tipping channels. And that is how a lot of people start believing them because they see the celebrity talking, right?”

For all the sophistication of the scams, however, there is no single profile of a likely victim. “Senior citizens may be less tech-savvy and therefore more vulnerable to clicking suspicious links,” Sourajeet says. “But it gets interesting when it comes to younger people as well, because threat actors are constantly finding out new ways to scam users. They’re getting better with time. So, I think anyone could be a target. It could be me, it could be you.”

That perhaps is the biggest takeaway from CloudSEK’s findings. The scams are no longer limited to obvious phishing emails or suspicious websites littered with spelling mistakes. Fake ticketing portals increasingly resemble legitimate platforms. Illegal streaming sites exploit search engine visibility and social media recommendations.

Betting operators leverage affiliate networks and even AI-generated celebrity

endorsements to gain credibility. In an environment where cyber criminals are constantly evolving their game-plan, awareness needs to become the first line of defence.

Researchers advise users to rely only on official ticketing partners, verify website URLs carefully before making payments, and avoid downloading software from streaming portals.

Anyone can be targeted

For authorities and sporting bodies, the challenge is equally continuous. “Cyber crime will happen no matter how hard you try to stop it. These kinds of scams will return every year,” Sourajeet says. “What can be done is to take proactive steps. Continuous monitoring can help identify fake ticketing sites, betting portals or malware-spreading domains as soon as they appear. Once they’re detected, the responsible agencies can work with registrars and hosting providers to take them down.”

As the IPL continues to grow into one of the world’s biggest sporting spectacles, so too does the shadow economy attempting to profit from it. The contest is no longer confined to the boundary rope, and vigilance may be the only winning strategy.

